for the evacuation. Paper work was done in utmost secrecy, and even the district collectors were told about the operation only hours in advance, just to get the official concurrence.

And the timing was great. The officials with the Armed Reserve Police literally stormed the property on a Friday night, so that the land owner wouldn't be able to get an official stay since the next two days were government holidays. Before Kurien could reach the spot, the gate was sealed and up came a board that announced it was a government property.

Kurien was furious. I later learned that some high-level government officials close to him drove some sense into him. There is always scope for some legal remedy, they told him, but don't forget that the operation had the blessings of none less than the Prime Minister of India. He did not pursue the case. Obviously, the rubber baron's influence did not stretch to the Prime Minister's Office.